Study Guide

In the style of Edexcel

To what extent does the Iranian Revolution of 1979 account for the growth of political Islam in the Middle East?

Exam tips

The cross-references are intended to take you straight to the material that will help you to answer the question.

Start by re-reading pages 118–20 of Chapter 7 and all of Chapter 9.

For this essay you need to assess the impact of the Islamic Revolution in Iran, and then the impact of *other* factors, on the growth of political Islam. Then, finally, make a judgement of how important the Iranian Revolution was in comparison to the other factors.

First, briefly explain what the Iranian Revolution achieved (i.e. the establishment of an Islamic state) and what this meant (pages 118–20). Then assess its impact on the wider Middle East, including the taking of US hostages. You will need to identify the limits of its impact as well, explaining the suspicions of the largely Sunni, Arab states and peoples. The revolutionary government in Iran was keen to spread its revolution: did the Iran–Iraq War inspire the growth of political Islam beyond Iran? If not, why not (pages 120–3)?

Other factors considered could include:

- The decline of Arab nationalism and its perceived failure in defending the Arab, Muslim world against the impact of the West and of Israel in particular (page 142).
- The appeal of political Islam as the best way to renew the Muslim world and expel foreign domination.
- The impact of defeat against Israel in 1967 and Egypt's peace with Israel in 1979.
- Most important of all, the emergence of al-Qaida in Afghanistan and then its later impact in Arab states like Egypt and Saudi Arabia (pages 144–6).
- The effects of the continuing Israeli–Palestinian conflict and of the US military presence in the Gulf in fuelling support for Islamic fundamentalism.
- The development of the al-Qaida network and its international bombing campaign. You might also refer to the growth of Islamic groups like Hamas and Hizbollah, the latter certainly supported by Iran (page 107).

In conclusion, you need to weigh up the importance of the Iranian revolution in relation to these other factors (and there may be some overlap, as in the case of Hizbollah's growth).

The very best answers will have weighed one factor against another as the essay developed. All the way through, therefore, there will have been mini-conclusions, so the conclusion at the very end will not be the only point at which the relative evaluation took place. Rather, it will complete the argument that ran through the whole essay.